

Description & Eligibility

Contestants will develop a comprehensive business plan and operating strategy for a new venture or startup. Contestants will prepare and present an investor-ready pitch designed to secure financing for their proposed business. Any secondary or postsecondary division contestant may enter this judged event. Contestants must be registered for the national competition before the submission deadline and compete in both parts of the event to be ranked. Entries that do not follow the provided topic or the Copyright and/or Fair Use Guidelines and the Artificial Intelligence Usage & Citation Policy will be disqualified.

Contestant Must Supply

- For each round of presentations (preliminaries and finals) the contestant may share supporting materials (e.g., research charts, brochures, etc.). These materials may be used during the presentation but must not be left with the judges
- Students may use one single-sided laptop, notebook, or tablet for their presentation. Projection equipment and external displays will not be provided or permitted
- Optional - Product displays and props (product samples and promotional items), prepared posters, flip charts, easels, or graphs in presentation

Contest Notes

- Method of evaluation: judged
- AI Policy Level 2 *Permitted with Citation*
- Carry-in and setup of equipment must be done solely by the contestants and take place within the time allotted
- No Internet access will be provided on-site at the NLC; however, contestants may provide their own access to be used only for their presentation to the judges
- No materials may be left with the judges
- At NLC, contestants will take the Entrepreneurship and Small Business (ESB) certification exam. Contestants passing this certification will have 50 points added to their event score.
 - A Pearson profile must be created at <https://certiport.pearsonvue.com> before attending NLC
 - Contestants must include their BPA Contestant ID in their Pearson profile when they register
 - Certiport Parent/Legal Guardian Consent Form must be uploaded to: education@bpa.org
 - For more information on the exam, visit <https://certiport.pearsonvue.com>
 - Reference materials are not allowed for certification testing
- Length of event: no more than three (3) minutes setup, no less than five (5) and no more than seven (7) minutes oral presentation, including the pitch to the investors, and no more than five (5) minutes judges' questions
 - No more than fifty (50) minutes for certification test
- Finals may be part of the competition
- Each state is allowed three (3) entries

Technical Pre-Submit Specifications

What to Submit at https://upload.bpa.org	Saved File Name(s)	National Deadline
Business Plan in one combined PDF to include: 1. Title Page 2. Table of Contents 3. Business Plan 4. Works Cited 5. BPA Release Form(s) 6. AI Usage and Documentation Form	ENT-ContestantID.pdf	April 1, 2027, 11:59 p.m. Eastern Time

Contest Competencies

1. Develop a comprehensive business plan that demonstrates understanding of entrepreneurship, feasibility, and startup requirements
2. Communicate research clearly and professionally in both written and oral formats
3. Identify and use internal and external resources that support business development and planning
4. Identify and analyze target customer groups, demographics, and customer relationship needs
5. Develop and justify pricing strategies based on customer value, costs, and competition
6. Prepare and justify the loan amount and financial data needed to establish the business, including startup costs and basic financial projections
7. Deliver clear, persuasive, and informative presentations that effectively communicate the business concept

Contest Specifications for this Event

- Business plan must reflect a new business for contestant's community or local area, *not* an expansion of a current business, subsidiary business, or franchise. If a contestant repeats this event, he/she may *not* submit any previously used business plan.
- Information in the business plan must be authentic; however, contestants may choose to use a fictitious address and telephone number.
- The Business Plan, including the Title Page, Table of Contents, and Works Cited must be formatted according to the *Style & Reference Manual*.
- The Business Plan must not exceed ten (10) pages single-sided and must follow the Business Plan format (Sections I-VIII) in the *Style & Reference Manual*. All other documentation is not considered to be part of the ten (10) single-sided pages. The Title Page, Table of Contents, and Works Cited are not included in the ten (10) page limit.
- Supporting documentation submitted separately during presentation **ONLY** may include layouts, brochures, flyers, business cards, résumés, product designs, prototypes, etc.
- Any Business Plan submitted beyond the maximum number of pages will be *disqualified*.

Common Specifications for all BPA Judged Events

- This is a pre-submitted event. Regional and state conferences have specific deadlines prior to the national deadlines. Please consult the regional or state conference administrator for those deadlines. For the National Leadership Conference, submit project files at <https://upload.bpa.org> no later than 11:59 p.m. Eastern Time on April 1, 2027.
- Contestant ID is required for all submissions. Materials from non-registered contestants and/or those missing Contestant ID cannot be accepted.
- The contestant is responsible for securing a signed BPA Release Form(s) from any person, including oneself, whose image or work is used in the project.
- The contestant is responsible for citing all sources, including oneself, on the Works Cited page for any work used on the project. It is the policy of Business Professionals of America to comply with copyright law. The *Style & Reference Manual* contains guidelines for Copyright and/or Fair Use. Contestants will be disqualified for violations of the guidelines.
- Materials must follow the organization's BPA Graphic Standards and make proper use of the BPA logo and/or organization's name. Refer to the BPA Graphic Standards in the *Style & Reference Manual*.
- Judges' comments will be returned digitally through the online judging system at the national level. Materials submitted for technical judging will *not* be returned and will *not* be available at NLC.

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Technical Scoring Rubric

Required Elements (If any question results in a NO, please assign a score of 0)				
Contestant followed the topic.				☐ Y ☐ N
Contestant followed the Copyright and/or Fair Use Guidelines and Artificial Intelligence Usage & Citation Policy.				☐ Y ☐ N
Business Plan did <i>not</i> exceed ten (10) pages single-sided. The Title Page, Table of Contents, and Works Cited are not included in the ten (10) page limit.				☐ Y ☐ N
If answered no to any question, please stop scoring and provide a brief reason for the <i>disqualification</i> :				
Submission and Formatting (All points or none are awarded by the technical judge)				
Contestant submitted one (1) combined PDF file containing their Business Plan to include the Title Page, Table of Contents, Works Cited formatted according to the <i>Style & Reference Manual</i> , BPA Release Form(s), and AI Usage and Documentation Form.				/10
Evaluation Criteria	Below Expectations 0-10 points	Meets Expectations 11-20 points	Above Expectations 21-30 points	Points Awarded
Executive Summary	Lacks detail, unclear, fails to engage.	Provides a clear overview but lacks engagement.	Compelling, detailed, thoroughly engages.	/30
Description of Proposed Business	Vague, lacks clarity, fails to intrigue.	Adequate description that generates interest.	Thorough, intriguing, captivates interest.	/30
Objectives of Business	Unclear or missing Mission and Vision.	Clear Mission and Vision with adequate objectives.	Clear, inspiring Mission and Vision.	/30
Proposed Business Strategies	Vague, unrealistic.	Realistic short-term and long-range plans.	Well-structured, innovative, achievable.	/30
Product(s) and/or Service(s)	Unclear, lacks detail, fails to differentiate.	Adequate description with some unique aspects.	Detailed, compelling, highlights advantages.	/30
Management and Ownership of the Business	Unclear, incomplete chart and roles.	Clear organizational chart with adequately described roles.	Comprehensive chart with detailed roles.	/30
Marketing Analysis	Poorly defined target market, unclear edge.	Clearly defines target market and competitive edge.	In-depth analysis, strong edge, justified pricing.	/30
Evaluation Criteria	Below Expectations 0-16 points	Meets Expectations 17-33 points	Above Expectations 34-50 points	Points Awarded
Financial Analysis	Incomplete, unrealistic financial information.	Provides adequate financial details, including a basic balance sheet.	Comprehensive, realistic, detailed balance sheet.	/50
Evaluation Criteria	Below Expectations 0-5 points	Meets Expectations 6-10 points	Above Expectations 11-15 points	Points Awarded
Overall Appearance, Conciseness, and Completeness	Plan is disorganized, wordy, or missing sections.	Plan is well-organized, concise, and complete.	Plan is exceptionally well-organized, concise, and complete.	/15
Writing Accuracy	Frequent grammar or spelling errors.	Contains some grammar or spelling errors.	Contains very few or no grammar or spelling errors.	/15
TOTAL TECHNICAL POINTS				/300

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Presentation Scoring Rubric

Required Elements (If any questions result in a NO being checked, judges please assign a score of 0)				
Contestant followed the topic.				☐ Y ☐ N
Contestant followed the Copyright and/or Fair Use Guidelines and Artificial Intelligence Usage & Citation Policy.				☐ Y ☐ N
If answered no to either question, please stop scoring and provide a brief reason for the <i>disqualification</i> :				
Evaluation Criteria	Below Expectations 0-5 points	Meets Expectations 6-10 points	Above Expectations 11-15 points	Points Awarded
Delivery & Engagement	Contestant rarely maintains eye contact, uses minimal gestures and body language, or has significant inconsistencies in tone and pace.	Contestant occasionally breaks eye contact, uses limited gestures and body language, or has some inconsistencies in tone and pace.	Contestant maintains good eye contact, uses appropriate gestures and body language, and varies their tone and pace adequately.	/15
Organization, Design & Structure	Presentation lacks coherence and structure, making it unclear and difficult to follow. Transitions between points are awkward or absent.	Presentation content has some gaps, making it not always clear and somewhat difficult to follow. Transitions between points are choppy.	Presentation content flows adequately, with a mostly clear structure and smooth transitions between points.	/15
Evaluation Criteria	Below Expectations 0-10 points	Meets Expectations 11-30 points	Above Expectations 31-50 points	Points Awarded
Content Knowledge	Presentation demonstrates a limited understanding of the topic and includes mostly irrelevant or inaccurate information.	Presentation demonstrates a basic understanding of the topic and includes a mix of relevant and irrelevant information.	Presentation demonstrates a good understanding of the topic and includes relevant and accurate information.	/50
Evaluation Criteria	Below Expectations 0-4 points	Meets Expectations 5-7 points	Above Expectations 8-10 points	Points Awarded
Judges' Questions	Responses lack depth and fail to demonstrate a comprehensive understanding of the topic.	Some responses lack detail or clarity. The understanding of the topic is partially demonstrated.	Responses are detailed, insightful, and effectively address the judges' questions.	/10
Timing	Setup lasted no longer than three (3) minutes, and the presentation lasted no less than five (5) and no more than seven (7) minutes.			/10
TOTAL PRESENTATION POINTS				/100

Props and/or additional items shall not be used as a basis for scoring.

PRESENTATION WILL BE STOPPED AT SEVEN (7) MINUTES